



December should be the culmination of the winter theme:

September = prepare

October = protect

November = monitor

December = trust the bees and support them when needed

DECEMBER – TRUSTING THE COLONY THROUGH WINTER

December is often the quietest month in the beekeeping year.

The excitement of spring is long gone.

The honey harvest is a distant memory.

Most hive management tasks have already been completed.

For the bees, winter survival is now the only priority.

For the beekeeper, patience becomes one of the most important skills.

The colony should now be largely left alone.

Your role is no longer to manage growth or maximise honey production.

Instead, your focus shifts to supporting the colony through the darkest part of the year.

The foundations laid during late summer and autumn will now determine how well your bees survive until spring.

THE DEEPEST PART OF WINTER

December brings the shortest days of the year.

Temperatures continue to fall.

Long periods of cold weather become increasingly common.

Flying opportunities may be limited to only a few mild days.

Forage is virtually non-existent.

The bees rely entirely on the food they collected earlier in the season.

Every decision inside the hive is focused on conserving energy.

The colony has entered its most efficient state.

Nothing is wasted.

Nothing is done unnecessarily.



Everything revolves around survival.

WHAT THE BEES ARE DOING

Inside the hive, the colony forms a winter cluster.

Thousands of bees gather tightly together around the queen.

The outer layer acts as insulation.

The bees in the centre generate heat by vibrating their flight muscles.

As temperatures change, the cluster expands and contracts.

The bees slowly move around stored honey and food reserves.

Contrary to popular belief, bees do not hibernate.

They remain active throughout winter.

They simply operate at a much lower level than during the summer months.

FOOD STORES REMAIN CRITICAL

December is one of the most important months for monitoring food reserves.

A healthy colony can survive remarkably low temperatures.

It cannot survive without food.

This is why experienced beekeepers continue to heft their hives throughout winter.

Hefting allows you to assess the weight of a hive without opening it.

Colonies that feel noticeably lighter than expected should be monitored closely.

If stores become low, action may be required.

REALITY CHECK: Cold rarely kills healthy colonies. Starvation remains one of the most common causes of winter losses.

USING FONDANT

By December, syrup feeding is generally no longer practical.

Temperatures are usually too low for bees to process large quantities effectively.

Fondant becomes the preferred emergency food source.

Many beekeepers place fondant above the cluster as insurance against unexpected shortages.



The aim is not to replace proper autumn feeding.

The aim is to prevent starvation if winter extends longer than expected.

When adding fondant:

- Work quickly
- Disturb the colony as little as possible
- Avoid prolonged exposure to cold air
- Position feed where the cluster can easily access it

Small interventions can make a significant difference to winter survival.

OXALIC ACID TREATMENT

For many beekeepers, December is associated with oxalic acid treatment.

This is often timed to coincide with a broodless or nearly broodless period.

Without sealed brood, varroa mites have fewer places to hide.

This allows treatments to be particularly effective.

Not every beekeeper follows the same treatment schedule.

However, December remains a common time to review varroa control strategies and prepare for mid-winter treatments where appropriate.

Always follow current regulations and manufacturer guidance when using any treatment products.

AVOID UNNECESSARY DISTURBANCE

One of the biggest mistakes beginners make during winter is opening hives too often.

Every disturbance forces the colony to expend valuable energy.

Heat is lost.

The cluster is disrupted.

The bees consume more stores.

December is generally not a month for inspections.

Most information can be gathered from outside the hive.

Useful observations include:

- Hive weight
- Entrance activity



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- Weather damage
- Pest activity
- Condition of straps and roofs
- Water ingress

Often the less you interfere, the better.

WINTER MOISTURE AND CONDENSATION

Many beekeepers focus entirely on temperature.

Moisture can be a far greater threat.

As bees generate heat, they also generate water vapour.

Without adequate ventilation and insulation, condensation develops.

Water dripping onto the cluster can quickly create problems.

Good winter management aims to keep colonies dry rather than excessively warm.

Signs of potential moisture issues include:

- Mould
- Excess condensation
- Damp hive roofs
- Wet crownboards

Maintaining a dry environment is one of the best things you can do for your bees during winter.

REALITY CHECK: A cold, dry hive is usually safer than a warm, damp hive.

WINTER PESTS AND PREDATORS

December is also a time to remain alert for pests.

Mice continue to seek warm shelter.

Mouse guards should remain in place.

Entrances should be checked regularly.

In some areas, woodpeckers may target hives during prolonged cold weather.

Their pecking can disturb the cluster and damage equipment.



A quick visual check during apiary visits helps identify problems before they become serious.

LEARNING FROM THE YEAR

Winter provides something that is often in short supply during the active season.

Time.

December is an excellent opportunity to review your records.

Consider:

- Which colonies performed best?
- Which queens impressed you?
- Which colonies struggled?
- Were there recurring disease issues?
- Was swarm control effective?
- What equipment would improve next season?

The answers often reveal valuable lessons.

Good beekeeping is built upon observation and continual improvement.

PLANNING FOR SPRING

Although spring may seem a long way off, preparations often begin during winter.

Many beekeepers use December to:

- Repair equipment
- Assemble frames
- Clean spare boxes
- Order foundation
- Purchase replacement equipment
- Plan colony expansion

By preparing early, you avoid shortages and delays when activity increases again.

Spring arrives faster than many people expect.

THE IMPORTANCE OF PATIENCE

December rewards restraint.



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The temptation to check on colonies can be strong.

The temptation to "help" can be even stronger.

However, healthy colonies have survived winters for thousands of years without human intervention.

Most colonies simply need:

- Adequate stores
- Protection from pests
- A dry hive
- Minimal disturbance

The less drama there is in December, the better.

Quiet hives are often healthy hives.

LOOKING TOWARDS JANUARY

As the year ends, colonies continue to conserve energy and slowly consume their winter stores.

The winter cluster remains active.

The queen remains protected.

The colony waits patiently for longer days and improving weather.

January will continue many of the same themes:

- Monitoring stores
- Watching weather conditions
- Protecting colonies from winter damage
- Preparing for the gradual return of brood rearing

For now, December is about stability.

No major interventions.

No major changes.

Simply supporting the colony until spring begins to return.

DECEMBER TAKEAWAY

December is not a month of action.

It is a month of observation.



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The beekeeper's job is to ensure colonies have food, remain dry, stay protected from pests and suffer as little disturbance as possible.

Trust the preparations made earlier in the year.

Trust the winter bees.

Trust the colony.

Then wait patiently for the first signs of spring.

REALITY CHECK: The best thing most beekeepers can do in December is make sure their bees have food, keep the hive dry, and leave the colony alone.